

The Basics of Locke's Epistemology

1. Introduction

Locke declares his attempt to be an epistemological one right at the outset of his *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (henceforth *Essay*).¹ He declares that his purpose is to evaluate the certainty of the assertions or 'judgments' that we make about the things that we claim to know, and to investigate the legitimacy of the basis on which we assert the degree of certainty that we assign these assertions. In doing so, Locke's attempt is more modest than those of his predecessors or his contemporaries. He declares in his 'Epistle to the Reader' at the beginning of the *Essay*, that his task is not to discover fresh truths about the world, but rather, to lay bare the parameters that would enable us to demarcate the legitimate ascertainment of knowledge claims from illegitimate ones. Locke, holds that the way to achieve such a demarcating filter lay in understanding the epistemological structure that enables the generation of knowledge. Thus, in a sense, Locke anticipated the Kantian project in so far as, he intended to examine the limits of human knowledge, though Locke's exploration is psychological in its nature in contrast to Kant's transcendental approach.

Now, one of the most prevalent modes of evaluating the certainty of a judgment amongst the Scholastics was to demonstrate that it could be validly inferred from premises that were already known to be certain. But more importantly, this appropriation of the Aristotelian schema of demonstration by the Scholastics was deeply rooted in the belief that certain self-evident truths were lodged within our minds, either by God or by some higher power, by virtue of which we could infer other truths from these first principles demonstratively. In other words, one of the most prevalent epistemological positions during Locke's time was to uphold the *innateness* of certain first principles and ideas. As we are aware, Descartes himself upheld such an epistemological belief in the innateness of certain ideas. Thus, though Locke does not deny the possibility of arriving at judgments with a great measure of certainty, he nevertheless maintains that the legitimate basis of the ascription of certainty does not lie in the fact of innateness, but rather in experience. Locke thus begins his *Essay* with the whole of Book I devoted solely to rejection of the possibility of upholding any principle or idea as being innate.

2. Locke's Arguments against Innate Ideas and Principles

Locke argues that those who claim that there are innate ideas and principles² do so because they hold that:

- a. we all have certain ideas and principles which are held as having *universal consent* (universal acceptance that these ideas and principles are true); and
- b. this universal consent can be explained *if and only if* these principles and ideas are taken to be innate in us, since ideas that come to us through experience varies with space and time, or with variation in the nature of individuals, and thus cannot be the source of these ideas and principles.

Locke acknowledges that some of us do in fact have these ideas or principles which are claimed to be innate. At the least, since those who speak of these ideas and make sense of these principles must have these ideas to speak about them in the first place. However, Locke argues that those who claim innateness of such ideas and principles do so because they

¹ John Locke, *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (Vols. I and II), collated and annotated by Alexander Campbell Frazer, New York: Dover Publications, 1959.

² For instance, the idea of God was held by some, like Descartes, to be innate. But more specifically, during this period many argued that principles of logic, such as the law of non-contradiction, and moral principles like 'stealing is wrong', were innate.

erroneously hold that these ideas and principles are present to all minds. We can label this as Locke's *factual argument*. That is to say, Locke claims that there are *in fact* no such universal ideas or principles which everyone has. He argues that children and 'idiots and company' do not have these so-called innate ideas and principles. Further, Locke holds that even when children come to have them, they do so in time, if and when taught, and that idiots operate without ever being explicitly aware of these ideas and principles. Thus, Locke argues that the upholders of innate ideas and innate principles are factually wrong in holding that people in fact have such principles and ideas.³ Further, Locke argues that *even if* there were certain principles and ideas that were shared by a 'vast majority of mankind', it would not prove that these principles were innate. In other words, universal consent to a principle, or universal agreement upon an idea, does not essentially entail that the principle or idea is innate, for it is possible that an alternative explanation can be legitimately provided for such universal consent. This can be called Locke's *logical argument*.

That is to say, Locke argues that those who uphold the theory of innate principles and ideas commit the logical fallacy of deducing a conclusion when it cannot be legitimately deduced from the premises. Thus, even if we do assume that the human race does universally accept certain principles or ideas, the fact of this universal agreement does not by itself entail that the idea or principle is innate.

Of course, Locke's factual argument already asserts that there are no such principles or ideas that have universal acceptance in the first place. But even if there were to be such an idea or a principle, Locke's logical argument contends that this would not be sufficient to prove that there are in fact innate ideas or principles.

Now, one may argue against Locke that his factual argument is erroneous, because it fails to acknowledge that though these ideas and principles are innate they can nevertheless be known only after one is initiated into discovering them. Thus, it could be argued against Locke that even idiots and children as well as 'barbarians' may have these ideas and principles, but are not yet aware of them since they have not been initiated towards their discovery. Hence, one could argue that even though children, idiots and 'barbarians' do not show any knowledge of these ideas or principles, this does not entail that they *do not have these ideas or principles in their minds*. Rather, it simply entails that they are not yet aware of having them.

But Locke counter-argues that such an argument for faith in the innateness of ideas and principles would then blur the distinction between innate ideas and ideas that are not innate. He argues that by the measure provided, all ideas would qualify as innate ideas since every idea and principle that is known by me could be claimed to be innately present in my mind, but known only later when I come to be appropriately initiated towards its discovery. In other words, even ideas that do not have universal consent, or ideas that come to me through experience, could be claimed to be innate, since the very experiencing of the object could be held as mere initiation towards the discovery of what was already innately in me. Thus, Locke holds that this would make the notion of innate ideas redundant, as all ideas could then be categorised under the category of innate ideas.

³ Exploration of the world, and the emergence of conditions that enabled extensive travel, had brought in knowledge of other cultures and people by Locke's time. This exposure to new cultures generated an awareness of the ideas, practices and beliefs of cultures that were different from those of Europe. Of course, the varying cultural practices found among non-European peoples were mostly seen as uncivilized or 'barbaric', yet these cultural discoveries, as can be seen from the discussion above, served directly as materials for Locke's argument.

3. Locke's Notion of Ideas

Having argued for the untenability of the innateness of any principles or ideas as the grounds for our knowledge, Locke dislodges the most accepted foundations of knowledge doing the rounds during his time, and thus manages to clear the way for presenting his picture of human understanding. Though it is clear from Book II of his *Essay* that Locke takes propositions to be the fundamental units of assertions of our knowledge claims, he holds all such assertions to be ultimately constituted by *ideas*. The term 'idea' was popular amongst the Scholastics of the time to denote the content of our memories, imaginations, sensations, thoughts or any other mental processes. Accordingly, Locke defines ideas in Book I of his *Essay* as 'whatsoever is the Object of the Understanding when a man thinks'. Thus, it is only natural for Locke to begin his project on a positive note through an analysis of the origin and nature of the various kinds of ideas that populate our minds. Thus, Book II of his *Essay* is devoted to the analysis of the nature and the source of our ideas.

Locke's emphatic rejection of any possibility of innate ideas or principles opens up the avenue for the claim that the only foundation of our knowledge is to be sought, alternatively, within the domain of our experience. However, it must be emphasized here that Locke, as we shall see in the following sections, does not hold that our knowledge itself comes directly from experience without any mediation whatsoever. What Locke does assert is that our knowledge claims or judgments or propositions are ultimately grounded upon ideas that have experience as their primary source. For Locke, the 'primary' or 'original' building blocks of our knowledge provided to us by experience are what he labels *simple ideas*. In other words, for Locke, simple ideas are ideas that are directly apprehended by our minds through the channels of experience.

4. Simple Ideas and Their Classification

In the very beginning of Book II of his *Essay*, Locke defines a simple idea as an idea that is unambiguous, clear and distinct, and is thus unvarying in its appearance or conception when apprehended by the mind. Locke attributes this clarity and distinctness of a simple idea to the fact that it cannot be further divided into simpler constituting ideas, and is thus a single, *simple idea*. For Locke, simple ideas are thus the windows that provide us the picture of the external world. Given that Locke upholds the position of Realism, for him simple ideas are not a product of our subjective creation, but are rather impressions that are made upon our minds by the objective qualities of 'external objects' that populate the world through sense perceptions or sensual experiences. Thus, adding to the definition of a simple idea, Locke in Book II of his *Essay* holds that simple ideas, by virtue of being passively received by the mind, cannot be created by the mind. The basic thought behind this claim being that had these simple ideas been a creation of the mind, a blind person could have ideas of colours, or the deaf could be in a position to create ideas of different pitches and notes. But the fact that they lack these ideas suggests that simple ideas, like the ideas of colour, sound, taste, etc., can never be taught, but can only be known through direct experience. Further, by virtue of the fact that these simple ideas are unanalyzable in terms of simpler ideas, they cannot be destroyed by any operations of the mind either.⁴

However, Locke uses the term 'experience' not merely in a broader sense to stand for 'outward' experiences provided to us by our five sensory organs, but also to accommodate our 'inward' experiences. Following this broader usage of the term 'experience', which for Locke is the primary and the only source of our simple ideas, he classifies simple ideas into two exclusive and exhaustive categories, namely, *simple ideas of sensation* and *simple ideas of reflection*. In his positive account of the origin and nature of the ideas in the mind, which begins in Book II of his *Essay*, Locke holds that simple ideas of sensation are those of our

⁴ It is also this unanalyzability of simple ideas that grounds Locke's claim, in Book III of his *Essay*, that simple ideas are indefinable.

distinct ideas that make us aware about the sensible qualities of objects in the external world, and that are furnished through our sense organs. Thus, ideas of colour, texture, taste, solidity and the like are what Locke would consider simple ideas of sensation. We must, however, be careful here that we do not conflate the idea of an external object, say, the idea of a 'table', with a simple idea of sensation. Clearly, the idea of a table is an idea that is constituted of many simpler discrete and distinct ideas provided to us by our sensation through our different sense organs. For instance, my eyes provide the shape, the size and the colour of the table, while my tactile sensations furnish me with an idea of its solidity or texture, like hardness, smoothness and the like. All these discrete simple ideas provided to me by my various senses then come to be collectively unified under the idea of a 'table' by my mind. In other words, for Locke, the idea of a table, or of any sensible object in the external world, is not, for that matter, a simple idea of sensation, since the idea of a 'table' can be broken down into other simpler ideas like those of colour or hardness. Such ideas that involve more than one simple idea are what Locke would classify as *complex ideas*. We shall turn to these kinds of ideas later. Returning to Locke's category of simple ideas of sensation, beginning in the third chapter of Book II in his *Essay*, based on the way in which these simple ideas of sensation make their way into our minds, Locke classifies them into two types: simple ideas of sensation *that come to us through one sense*, and simple ideas of sensation *that come to us through more than one sense*. The former class of simple ideas has a singular, dedicated channel of approaching our mind that is 'peculiarly adapted to receive them'. For instance, simple ideas of colour can only approach our minds through the medium of the eyes, those of sound through the ears, those of taste through the palate and smells through the nose. In contrast, there are simple ideas of sensation that come to us through more than one sense. Thus, simple ideas of sensation like those of extension, figure, motion or rest can come to us either through the medium of touch or through that of sight. For instance, I can touch and feel an object to come to have ideas about its shape, size, or whether it is in motion or at rest. Alternatively, I may come to gather these very ideas about the object by simply looking at it.

But then, Locke holds that in addition to the simple ideas of sensation that help us ground our beliefs about the external world and that are furnished to our minds through our senses, we also have simple ideas of reflection. These simple ideas of reflection provide us with ideas about the processes or operations of our own minds. Thus for Locke, ideas that stand for our mental processes, like 'perception', 'thinking', 'believing', 'willing', 'doubting', 'choosing', 'imagining', 'remembering', 'reasoning', 'knowing', or ideas about other *operations of our minds*, constitute the class of simple ideas of reflection. Simple ideas of reflection are thus those ideas of the mind that furnish us with ideas that enable us to understand the various operations of the mind, that enables us to formulate our beliefs and knowledge claims. Locke holds that these simple ideas of reflection come to us when the mind takes an introspective or an 'inward turn', and begins to reflect on its own nature and operations. Thus, according to Locke, though we do perceive things right from our birth, this does not entail that we have an idea of 'perception' itself. We could, likewise, be engaged in thinking about various things, without the awareness that we are 'thinking'. This awareness that we are thinking can only emerge when the mind begins to think about its own operation of thinking, and, in taking this inward turn and making itself the object of our reflection, comes to be furnished with the simple idea of 'thinking'. This is why Locke argues that unlike simple ideas of sensation that all of us come to be equipped with naturally by virtue of our sensations, ideas of reflection do not necessarily come to those who are incapable or fail to take the inward turn. Further, given that Locke takes such ideas of reflection to be simple ideas, and thus received by the mind in a degree of passivity, he considers these ideas as not requiring any proof. That is, Locke holds that it is illegitimate on our part to demand a proof for the fact that 'we think', for the idea of 'thinking' is an idea that is directly received by the mind when it is self-reflective. But since these simple ideas of reflection require the operations of the mind to be the very object of our understanding, it therefore entails that the mind must already be equipped with some

ideas of sensation upon which it can in fact act before we can have simple ideas of reflection. Thus, Locke holds that our simple ideas of sensation precede our simple ideas of reflection.

In the seventh chapter of Book II of his *Essay*, Locke provides us with a third category of simple ideas, commonly labelled *simple accompanying ideas*. This category of simple ideas, for Locke, consists of ideas that 'join themselves to almost all our ideas of sensation and reflection'. Though Locke does not provide us a clear picture about the originary grounds of such accompanying ideas, what can, at the least, be certainly asserted about these ideas is that Locke held them to be simple ideas, and hence not a creation of the mind but rather ideas that are merely received by it. Further, he asserts that such accompanying ideas are distinct from the simple ideas of either sensation or reflection that they accompany. Ideas of 'pleasure' and 'pain', or 'delight and uneasiness', both bodily as well as those arising by virtue of thoughts, along with other ideas of 'existence', 'unity', 'power' and 'succession', are, for Locke, such accompanying ideas. That is to say, for Locke almost all our simple ideas of sensation and reflection are accompanied by:

- a. the idea of *pain* or *pleasure*;
- b. the idea that one has the capacity to bring about a change in another body (the idea that one has the power to be a *cause*);
- c. the idea that one idea temporally follows another idea (idea of *succession*); and
- d. the idea that every simple idea of sensation or reflection brings along with it the idea that it really *exists*.

The formulation of this third category of simple ideas not only shows that Locke upholds the tenets of Realism, but, more importantly, it enables us to understand that for Locke, given that the ideas of 'existence' as well as 'cause' are simple accompanying ideas, the reality of the external world and of casual relations are beyond our doubt.⁵

5. Complex Ideas

Locke's epistemological framework begins with the rejection of innate ideas, and conceives the mind in its first instance to be akin 'to a white paper',⁶ devoid of any marks or ideas. Further, since he holds that the foundational ideas of knowledge are the simple ideas that are furnished to us through experience,⁷ his epistemological framework therefore crystallizes the principle *that all our knowledge is ultimately based upon ideas given to us by the natural source of experience*. This principle, by the twentieth century, was seen as the hallmark of what came to be known as *empiricism*.

Locke's claim that the mind is devoid of any contents prior to the furnishing of simple ideas of sensation through the natural source of experience is confined precisely to the absence of ideas in our minds. However, it must be borne in mind that Locke holds that the mind already has in place its 'natural operations' through which it acts upon the ideas that we

⁵ Notions such as 'existence', 'unity' and 'power' are a source of enigma for later thinkers like Hume precisely because they do not agree with Locke's formulation of the third category of simple ideas, namely, simple accompanying ideas. Locke's view that the ideas of 'existence' and 'unity' are simple ideas enables him to relate the simple ideas of sensation to primary and secondary qualities. Locke elaborates upon this further in the fourth chapter of Book III of his *Essay*.

⁶ The notion of the mind in its pure state as devoid of any ideas had been earlier explored by Aristotle, and was a significant thesis of the Stoics. It was also explored by Avicenna and Aquinas. However, Locke undertook a systematic exploration of this thesis in its positive aspect to construct an entire system of epistemology.

⁷ In Book IV, Locke does seem to talk about the possibility of yet another kind of simple idea that could be furnished to our minds, namely, ideas that come 'from the immediate hand of God', but he does not elaborate upon this in greater detail.

receive through our sensations.⁸ Thus, our experiences furnish us with simple ideas of sensation upon which the natural operations of the mind act, consequently leading to the emergence of the entire edifice of human knowledge. Locke describes a whole set of operations of the mind in chapters nine to eleven of Book II of his *Essay*, the crucial ones being 'distinguishing', 'compounding' or bringing together simpler ideas to form another distinct idea, 'comparing', and 'abstracting'.

Given the range of simple ideas that come to populate our minds through the source of experience, and given our mind's *faculty of retention*, which allows us to 'revive these ideas again in our minds', Locke argues that we consequently manage to construct a variety of ideas by subjecting these simple ideas to the various operations of the mind. Ideas that are created through the various operations of the mind upon simple ideas are categorized by Locke as *complex ideas*. Thus, the first distinguishing feature of complex ideas is that, in contrast to simple ideas, they are generated when the mind actively works upon our simple ideas. Thus, ideas of particular objects, say a 'table' or a 'dog', are complex ideas, which are constituted by the mind by 'compounding' many simple ideas together. However, a complex idea is nevertheless construed by the mind as a single entity or idea, and thus we can 'signify it by one name'. In other words, every complex idea, though a complex, can still be construed by the mind as a unity, and thus can be subjected to further operations to give rise to a whole range of more complex ideas.⁹ For instance, the mind can combine the complex ideas of a house, a street, people, etc., to generate a more complex idea of a 'neighbourhood'.

6. Classification of Complex Ideas

A large section of Book II of the *Essay* deals with Locke's attempt to show how the various complex ideas that furnish our minds are built from our simple ideas of sensation and reflection.

Locke divides complex ideas into three categories, namely, *complex ideas of modes*, *complex ideas of substance*, and *complex ideas of relations*. Since his purpose is to establish the thesis that all of our complex ideas can be shown to be ultimately grounded upon simple ideas, Locke proceeds to show how the various complex ideas that furnish our minds can be shown to be either simple ideas of sensation or reflection themselves, or complex ideas based upon them.

Locke holds that most of our complex ideas are constituted by the mind by 'compounding' many simple ideas which 'constantly' occur together, leading us to construe this compounded complex idea as representing a single object or entity. Locke categorizes such complex ideas as 'complex ideas of substance'. Thus, ideas that represent objects in the world, like a table or a chair, a rose or an individual, are, for Locke, complex ideas of substance. Elaborating upon these further in chapter twenty-three of Book II of his *Essay*, Locke argues that these complex ideas of substance compel us to uphold the notion of a 'substratum' or a 'substance' which comes to be construed by the mind as the source of the various simple ideas furnished to it that constitute the complex idea of that particular entity.¹⁰ Locke further classifies complex ideas of substance into two further categories, *complex ideas of single substance* and *complex ideas of collective substance*. The complex idea of a 'table', or that of a 'sheep', which denotes a single individual or a single entity,

⁸ The emergence of the postulate of the 'powers of the mind' significantly contributed to the steady development of modern psychology.

⁹ It is interesting to note that Locke does not place the idea of beauty within the realm of simple ideas but rather within the domain of complex ideas. This enables him to explain the variation in our conceptions of beauty.

¹⁰ Locke however clarifies that the mind has no idea corresponding to the notion of a substratum. He argues in similar fashion for the idea of 'self' as an 'immaterial or spiritual substratum' for the originary grounds of our simple ideas of reflection.

would fall under the former category, while the complex idea of 'furniture' or a 'flock of sheep' or the idea of an 'army', which denote groups of entities, would fall under the latter category.

In contrast to these complex ideas of substance, Locke holds that some of our complex ideas highlight demonstrate a dependency upon some other idea for their very existence. Such complex ideas are what Locke labels 'complex ideas of modes', which are further divided into *complex ideas of simple modes* and *complex ideas of mixed modes*. In other words, complex ideas of modes are those complex ideas that do not bring along with them the simple accompanying idea of 'existence'. Thus, though Locke holds the idea of a 'unit' to be a simple accompanying idea provided to us as the idea of unity, he nevertheless holds that the idea of '2' or 'a dozen' or the idea of any other number is a complex idea of simple modes. That is, Locke holds that the idea of the number '2', for instance, is construed by the mind by simply compounding the simple idea of a unit by repeating it twice, and thus the idea of '2' cannot be independently conceived without relying on the idea of a unit. In other words, in Locke's view, though the idea of '2' has an independent word to denote it, namely, 'two', it nevertheless does not bring along with it the simple accompanying idea of existence. In addition to complex ideas of simple modes, Locke formulated the category of complex ideas of mixed modes. These, for Locke, consist of those complex ideas that the mind arrives at by compounding simple ideas of various kinds, rather than of a singular kind. Ideas of 'obligation', 'a lie', 'drunkenness', 'murder', 'gratitude' and 'beauty' are all examples of complex ideas of mixed modes. For Locke, no complex idea of modes, either simple or mixed, can be conceived to exist independently; thus, one cannot conceive of gratitude just existing on its own without conceiving of someone who feels that gratitude or is the object of someone's gratitude.¹¹

Apart from the complex ideas of substance and modes, Locke's third category of complex ideas consists of complex ideas of relation. According to Locke, through the operation of 'comparing', the mind can relate two ideas to form a complex idea of relation. Thus, for instance, by comparing two simple ideas of two distinct shades of white, the mind could generate the complex idea of 'whiter' or 'brighter'. But more importantly, Locke holds that our complex ideas of relation also include those complex ideas that essentially implicate another idea in a relation. Thus, the idea of 'husband' or 'friend' is a complex idea of relation as well, given that the idea of a 'husband' essentially evokes the relation of a man with a woman, and the idea of a 'friend' evokes the relation of one individual with another.

Before we end this discussion, we must touch briefly upon Locke's treatment of universal or abstract ideas.

7. Locke on Abstract Ideas

Locke holds the mind's operation of 'abstraction' to be responsible for the generation of our abstract ideas. For Locke, these ideas enable us to proceed further with the construction of our edifice of knowledge. 'Abstraction' is one operation that the minds of other animals or 'brutes' lacks, thereby acting as a distinguishing mark of the human mind. Abstract ideas, since Plato, have been held to be of cardinal importance to the very activity of thinking, given the role these ideas play in the advancement of our knowledge. It is through the employment of abstract ideas that we categorize things into classes and open up the possibility of the use of common terms, without which our language itself would collapse. Likewise, Locke maintains that abstract ideas help us economize on naming our ideas by enabling us to refer to many particular ideas of the same kind by a common name. However, Locke believes that such

¹¹ Locke's category of complex ideas of modes is of great importance to his reflections on morality, given that he employs the notion of modes to elucidate our ideas of morality. Locke believes that a large number of our moral ideas are complex ideas of mixed modes that combine simple ideas of reflection as well as of sensation to form a single complex idea.

universal ideas are not merely hollow linguistic denominators, but rather refer to a concrete and a distinct kind of idea that is construed by the mind by abstracting all the accidental simple ideas from a particular complex idea of an entity. Thus, for Locke, the operation of 'abstraction' enables the mind to abstract all spatial and temporal ideas associated with a particular complex idea, thereby enabling the generation of an abstract idea that stands for all the members of the class to which the particular complex idea belongs.

8. Ideas and Knowledge

After presenting this elaborate outline of the apparatus through which the mind forms its varieties of ideas, Locke draws out an elaborate schema of the modes in which we engage with these ideas as language users by forming judgments and expressing them in terms of knowledge claims. An elaborate description of this schema would lead us into Locke's theory of language and meaning formations, which is beyond the scope of our present purpose. It must, however, be mentioned here that Locke held that knowledge is determined by the nature of relations that obtain between our ideas. Our ideas are either in a relationship of 'agreement' or 'connection', or in a relationship of 'disagreement' or 'repugnancy'. That is, either our ideas are found to be compatibly and consistently related, or they are found to be incompatible and inconsistent with each other. Such relations between ideas are what constitute knowledge for Locke. Locke maintains that in some cases, for instance, in a large number of mathematical axioms, this relation of agreement or disagreement between ideas can be known as *intuitive*. That is, they are immediately clear to the mind as being necessarily related. Locke considers such knowledge as intuitively known. However, there might be other knowledge claims or relations of ideas that, though do not intuitively appear as self-evidently connected, nevertheless manage to reveal their consistency and the necessity of being related in the manner in which they are, when mediated by other ideas. Such knowledge that requires the mediation of some other ideas is what Locke describes as knowledge that can be known *demonstratively*. Locke holds that in cases of intuitive knowledge, the relation between ideas is either of *identity* or of *diversity*. For instance, claims like 'green is green', or 'green is black', can be immediately known as being true or false intuitively without the mediation of any other idea. On the other hand, Locke sees demonstrative knowledge as ensuing from ideas that are in a *relation* where, through the mediation of some other idea, it can be seen that the related ideas are necessarily related thus. For instance, the mediation of the idea of 'human' enables us to see the truth of the relation between the idea of 'Hari' and 'mortality'.

In addition, to these kinds of knowledge, Locke believes that one can have *sensitive knowledge*, or knowledge about the external world that is given to us by our senses. However, in contrast to intuitive and demonstrative knowledge, the relations between ideas in sensitive knowledge claims are neither intuitively nor demonstrative known, but can be asserted only through 'observation and experiments'. Thus, Locke distinguishes between the exact sciences like mathematics,¹² where we have assertions of knowledge claims that are either intuitively or demonstratively known, and the natural sciences, which operate at the level of *belief*, rather than knowledge proper. In this respect, Locke provides a higher level of certitude to the exact sciences than is available to the natural sciences, a claim that Hume later explores to its logical extreme.

Locke's epistemological framework has often been critiqued for using the notion of 'idea' in a very different, distinct and ambiguous way. For instance, Locke employs the notion of idea to denote both the impressions made on our minds as well as what the mind would make of those impressions. While Locke upholds the position of Realism, as highlighted by his treatment of simple ideas and their relation to the notion of qualities, his epistemological position often seems to land in uncertain terrain. Since the mind can never go beyond its own ideas, one has no way of figuring out if an idea in fact consistently and faithfully represents

¹²It should be noted that Locke treats morality as an exact science.

what it is representing, namely, the qualities of the object. This cardinal problem faced by Locke's epistemological position is often dubbed as the *problem of representation*.¹³ Further, though Locke's epistemological framework can be accused of assuming that a descriptive account of the production of our knowledge could also justify itself by virtue of this very description, it nevertheless ushered in a new mode of engaging with the question of knowledge. It highlighted the possibility of establishing a mechanistic and natural mode of explaining the possibility and the limits of human knowledge. This possibility had tremendous influence upon Locke's contemporaries and upon thinkers who came after him, like Berkley, Hume, Reid and Mill, among others.



¹³ The problem of representation, though an epistemological issue, is deeply rooted in Locke's metaphysical thesis about the mode in which the primary and secondary qualities manage to generate simple ideas of sensation in us. It will be dealt with in greater detail when we discuss Locke's metaphysical system.